SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #108 · SUFFERING

“I must figure out the reason for everything bad that happens.”

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Where it often comes from

A need for control and certainty. Anxiety that searches for answers to feel safe. Teaching that every event has a clear, knowable purpose. Painful events that seem senseless. Feeling that you cannot move on until you understand.

What Scripture teaches

God has purposes in all things, but He does not always reveal them to us. The secret things belong to the LORD, while the things revealed belong to us. Even the wise cannot comprehend all of God’s work under the sun. Jesus told Peter, “You do not realize now what I am doing, but later you will understand.” Like a weaned child resting with its mother, we can quiet our souls before God without needing every answer.

> *“The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things revealed belong to us and to our children forever, so that we may follow all the words of this law”* **(Deuteronomy 29:29)**.

Also see

> “My heart is not proud, O LORD, my eyes are not haughty. I do not aspire to great things or matters too lofty for me. Surely I have stilled and quieted my soul; like a weaned child with his mother, like a weaned child is my soul within me” **(Psalm 131:1–2)**.

> “I saw every work of God, and that a man is unable to comprehend the work that is done under the sun. Despite his efforts to search it out, he cannot find its meaning; even if the wise man claims to know, he is unable to comprehend” **(Ecclesiastes 8:17)**.

> “Jesus replied, ‘You do not realize now what I am doing, but later you will understand.’” **(John 13:7)**.

> “‘For My thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways My ways,’ declares the LORD. ‘For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so My ways are higher than your ways and My thoughts than your thoughts.’” **(Isaiah 55:8–9)**.

Common self-statements

- I can’t rest until I know why this happened.
- There must be a reason, and I have to find it.
- If I understood, I could accept it.
- Not knowing means God doesn’t care.
- I keep replaying it looking for answers.
- Other people seem to understand their suffering.

Common logical errors

- **Intolerance of uncertainty:** Needing to understand everything before you can have peace.
- **Rumination:** Going over events again and again looking for answers.
- **Mind reading:** Assuming you can know God’s specific reasons.

- **Control-seeking:** Trying to manage pain by figuring it out.

Challenging questions

- What does Deuteronomy 29:29 say about secret things?
- Can even the wise understand all of God's work?
- What did Jesus tell Peter about understanding later?
- Has searching for reasons brought me peace or more anxiety?
- Can I trust God without knowing why?
- What does it mean to quiet my soul like a weaned child?
- What has God revealed that I can act on today?

Truth summary

> I do not have to figure out the reason for everything bad that happens. Some things belong to God alone. I may understand later, or not in this life. I can quiet my soul before God, trust His character, and focus on what He has revealed and what I can do today.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Confusion
- Suffering
- Peace
- God, All Knowing

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must figure out the reason for everything bad that happens"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must figure out the reason for everything bad that happens." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What belongs to God alone?
- ☐ Can even the wise understand all of God's work?
- ☐ What did Jesus say about understanding later?
- ☐ Has searching brought peace or anxiety?
- ☐ Can I trust God without knowing why?
- ☐ What can I act on today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ The secret things belong to God.
- ☐ I can trust God without knowing why.
- ☐ I may understand later, or not in this life.
- ☐ I can quiet my soul before God.
- ☐ God's ways are higher than mine.
- ☐ I can focus on what God has revealed.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Deuteronomy 29:29**
  "The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things revealed belong to us and to our children forever, so that we may follow all the words of this law."
- [ ] **Psalm 131:1–2**
  "My heart is not proud, O LORD, my eyes are not haughty. I do not aspire to great things or matters too lofty for me. Surely I have stilled and quieted my soul; like a weaned child with his mother, like a weaned child is my soul within me."
- [ ] **Ecclesiastes 8:17**
  "I saw every work of God, and that a man is unable to comprehend the work that is done under the sun. Despite his efforts to search it out, he cannot find its meaning; even if the wise man claims to know, he is unable to comprehend."
- [ ] **John 13:7**
  "Jesus replied, 'You do not realize now what I am doing, but later you will understand.'"
- [ ] **Isaiah 55:8–9**
  "'For My thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways My ways,' declares the LORD. 'For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so My ways are higher than your ways and My thoughts than your thoughts.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Let-it-rest log:** When I start searching for "why," write the question, then write: "This belongs to God," and one thing I can do today.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Psalm 131:2 becomes: "Surely **Sarah** has stilled and quieted **her** soul; like a weaned child with **her** mother, like a weaned child is **her** soul within **her**."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Set a 15-minute "worry time" each day** for questions about why; outside that time, gently set them aside.
- ☐ **Read Psalm 131 slowly each morning,** and practice resting quietly for two minutes.
- ☐ **Write a letter to God** with your questions, and end with "I trust You."
- ☐ **Talk with a counselor** if searching for answers is keeping you stuck.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must figure out the reason for everything bad that happens": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One time I let a "why" rest
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must figure out the reason for everything bad that happens.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You know the questions I carry. Help me reject the lie that I must figure out the reason for everything bad that happens. Teach me to quiet my soul before You, to trust You with the secret things, and to walk faithfully in what You have shown me. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.